MICROSOFT 365 COPILOT COWORK · **FINANCE & FINOPS** · FREE, MIT LICENSE

Budget Variance Explainer

Writes the story behind a number somebody else owns.

Do this, about two minutes

1. **Download the skill file**
   budget-variance-explainer.zip
   github.com/kesslernity/awesome-copilot-cowork-bots ↓
2. In Cowork, open **Customize** from the left navigation
3. Go to the **Skills** tab
4. Select the arrow next to **Add**, then **Upload skill**, and choose the file
5. Start a **new** chat and say one of these

> *"Why are we over budget?"*

> *"Explain this variance"*

> *"What is behind the overspend?"*

Written to prepare and stop. Cowork still asks before it sends, so approve one action at a time and avoid **always allow** while you are trying it. **AI prepares, people decide.**

And you get back

- Written commentary in your house structure
- A table of causes, with evidence and how much each explains
- The remainder that stays unexplained, stated plainly

What it will never do without asking you

- Never calculate, recalculate or forecast. Not even arithmetic on supplied figures.
- Never state a cause as certain when the evidence is circumstantial. Label it.
- Never write commentary that attributes a variance to a named individual.

THE RULE IT FOLLOWS

"Largely unexplained" is an honest and useful answer.

Runs when you ask for it. Want it on a timer? Say *"do this every Monday at 9"* and Cowork schedules it. You get 25 schedules, so spend them on the jobs you would otherwise forget.

DESKTOP ONLY
Cowork runs on mobile. Uploaded skills do not. Use a laptop.

YOU NEED
Microsoft 365 Copilot, and Cowork switched on by your admin. Off by default.

IT IS METERED
Cowork bills Copilot Credits as you use it. Your admin sets the policy.

READ IT FIRST
A skill is instructions to the AI. Open the zip and read SKILL.md first; it is plain text.

By Mathieu Kessler · **kesslernity.com/store** · v1.0, Nov 2026

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